

LAWS NEED TO BE TIGHTENED TO DETER TERROR FUNDING AND ENSURE CHEMICALS ARE NOT USED TO MAKE BOMBS.

says, "In vulnerable metros, the police stations should be upgraded to the level of anti-terrorism squads and should be the first responder to a terror attack. Their response time in an urban terrorism exigency should be shaped up to between one and three minutes."

Also, as Joginder Singh, a former CBI director, says, "The scale and sophistication of terrorism that we face has the capacity to overwhelm our security mechanism which lacks human resource and technology. New York city alone has 50,000 CC TV cameras—even inside the mosques. We don't have so many CC TV cameras at public places in the entire country."

What experts are suggesting is that since terror strikes tend to concentrate on India's major metros, there is a need for the concept of mega city policing—where each city becomes a well-guarded fortress of policemen with its own NSG unit, top class intelligence set-up and surveillance equipment, in short a world-class force.

Clearly there is much more to be done for India to effectively combat the threat of terror. There need to be stringent laws and monitoring systems to check the sale of sensitive chemicals that can be used to make explosives. Also an effective agency to investigate illegal source of funds for terrorism and clamp down on it. There is also a need to bring greater accountability into the system with officials facing the sack for major lapses in security.

Equally important is the development of a counter-terrorism doctrine. This involves both offensive military and law enforcement measures against terrorists and winning the hearts and minds of the target population. The roadmap to combat terrorism has to be comprehensive and involve the three critical elements of anti-terrorism—consequence management and counter terrorism, underpinned by intelligence. India must go down the road to reform quickly.

With Ramesh Vinayak

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